

Brothers and Others: Organizing Masculinity, Disorganizing Workers

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Sociologists have long argued that hegemonic masculinity serves as an organizing tool, uniting men around a collective identity by excluding women and subordinate men. This article reformulates existing theories by analyzing organizing drives among an occupationally segregated, ethnically diverse group of men. Ten months of participant observation and 30 in-depth interviews with street vendors in New York City revealed how the exclusionary processes involved in constructing a collective gendered identity can disrupt solidarity and collective action. Organizers attempted to orient members around “brotherhood” in a context where disparate cultural histories and occupational networks shaped interpretive disagreements over masculinity. These interpretive disagreements eventually alienated members and undermined mobilization. Organizational failures such as these allude to the limits social movements face in manipulating gender for institutional purposes. These limits may be especially relevant for resource poor, voluntary organizations that preside over a heterogeneous base. Keywords: masculinities; social organization; intersectionality; collective identity; boundary work.

Amidst the din of an especially well-attended organizing meeting for street vendors, voices called for “brotherhood.” Members had gathered to plan a protest. The issue was fines. Having already organized several rallies to no avail, leaders within the organization were pushing for something more drastic. John, an energetic African American board member rallied members around a 24-hour hour vigil.¹ “This is it brothers! Let’s show them what we’re made of.” Following John, a newly elected Egyptian board member, Hamid, continued to deploy the brotherly metaphor, exhorting members on the need for fraternal sacrifice. Despite such encouragement, a group of Bangladeshi and Senegalese vendors muttered discontentedly in one corner of the room. To them, the protest exemplified Vendors for Justice’s (VFJ) failure to support their efforts at being stable breadwinners. In the end, such reservations outweighed John and Hamid’s motivational speeches. Instead of ratifying the protest, the Bangladeshis and Senegalese, two of the largest ethnic groups within the vending community, walked out of the meeting. The campaign imploded.

These interactions took place within the offices of VFJ, an organization that brings together street vendors in New York City. By invoking brotherhood, VFJ leaders John and Hamid were not only invoking familial bonds. They were actively constructing and recruiting members around a collective identity, a notion of masculinity linked to militancy and courage. Yet, their efforts failed. A number of men in the room simply walked out.

Why did this particular group of men fail to agree on a hegemonic masculine identity? How did their identity failures shape solidarity and mobilization? Gender scholars have long argued that hegemonic notions of masculinity help consolidate a sense of superiority among men by

1. Names of individuals and organizations have been changed to ensure privacy.

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excluding women and subordinate men. In the context of social movement organizations these gendered exclusions ostensibly build solidarity among male workers. By conducting boundary work between “us” and “them,” movement participants bond with each other and feel motivated to undertake collective risks. My research challenges this scholarship. I argue that the exclusionary processes inherent to collective gender identity formation can undermine hegemony and destabilize collective action, even for men.

The analysis presented here is based on data from ten months of participant observation and 30 semistructured interviews with members of a street vendors’ organization in New York City that I call “Vendors for Justice” (VFJ). VFJ’s members included a predominantly male, ethnically diverse, and occupationally segmented labor force. Attempting to unify its diverse base and overcome resource constraints, VFJ’s leaders rallied members around a collective gendered identity of brotherhood. Despite their collective aspirations, organizers constructed brotherhood through a series of abjections, othering not only femininity but also alternative notions of masculinity that were salient for men within the organization. VFJ members espoused three distinct rhetorics around masculinity, each shaped by the intersection of gender, class, and ethnicity within their lives. Brotherhood selectively recognized two of these three rhetorics as legitimate forms of masculine comportment, sanctioning and censuring errant men. These exclusions rebounded on the organization, fracturing the very collectivity brotherhood was meant to create. Far from unifying members, the boundary work involved in creating a hegemonic masculinity alienated potential participants, further weakening an already unstable organizing climate.

This study highlights the limits organizations face in manipulating gender for institutional purposes. Social movements may fail to recruit believers when they construct gender in overly narrow or exclusive ways. These failures are more likely to occur within voluntary, resource-poor organizations like VFJ that have limited disciplinary powers over their membership base. Within this kind of organizational context discursive exclusions can easily have adverse effects, estranging members and rupturing solidarity. My findings also indicate that sociologists need to develop more robust understandings of masculinity as an intersectional category. Deploying masculinity does not always lend itself to hegemonic projects. Like femininity, masculinity may also be a frail and tenuous construction.

The remainder of this article is organized into four sections. In the following section, I review the literature on masculinity, arguing that the construction of hegemonic gender identities may not always be productive for organizational goals. The methods section describes the research setting, provides information about vendors in New York City, details the interviews and ethnography I conducted, and introduces the reader to my analytic strategy. The results section is subdivided into three parts. “Boundary Work” traces VFJ leaders’ efforts to create brotherhood, a hegemonic masculine identity linked to equality and militancy, constructed through boundary work between men and women within the organization. “Interpretive Disagreements” reveals how brotherhood not only drew boundaries between men and women, it privileged only two out of three very different discourses of masculinity that floated around the organization. “Organizational Disruptions” shows how brotherhood inadvertently disrupted the very solidarity it was meant to forge by marginalizing alternative notions of masculinity and alienating men. Finally, in the conclusion, I discuss the broader implications of the study.

Theorizing Masculinity and Collective Action

Studies of masculinity and social organization have long argued that hegemonic masculinity, the set of manhood acts aimed at claiming privilege, eliciting deference, and resisting exploitation, creates solidarity among men (Connell 1995; Schrock and Schwalbe 2009). These studies contend that hegemonic masculinity is an effective organizational tool *because* it creates a “we” by excluding women and subordinate men. Diverse social institutions, from work places to labor movements, use hegemonic masculinity to mobilize men around collective goals. In this section,

I take issue with this established understanding. The exclusionary processes that are central to hegemonic constructs can undermine the very solidarity such identities are meant to elicit. Drawing on intersectional analysis and literature on the new social movements, I argue that scholars of masculinity have paid insufficient attention to the frail and tenuous quality of masculine identity construction, ignoring the potentially deleterious effects such constructs have on organizational life.

The case for the power and efficacy of hegemonic masculinity is seemingly straightforward. By endowing men with a collective sense of superiority, hegemonic masculinity can motivate men towards myriad goals: financial independence, virility, physical prowess, and the ability to inflict and withstand violence (Bird 1996; Collier 1998; Gillet and White 1992; Kersten 1996; Martin 1998; Pierce 1996; Tomsen 1998). From “high tech” professionals to blue-collar workers, masculinity is shown to promote collective identification (Cockburn 1991; Collinson, Knights, and Collinson 1990; Messerschmidt 1995; Messner 1997; Mills 1998; Mumby 1998; Telford 1996; Willis 1997).

Building on these observations, a large body of literature has focused on the mechanisms behind hegemony. Some are highly visible, such as the “pageantry” of masculinity in television sports broadcasts (Sabo et al. 1996). Other mechanisms operate through invisibility, removing a dominant form of masculinity from public scrutiny while opening subordinated groups to social mechanisms of “censure” (Brown 1999; Consalvo 2003; Roberts 1993). Broadly, these studies agree that exclusion, abjection, and processes of “othering” are critical to the reproduction of hegemonic gender forms. Boundary work helps shape group identification and categorization, defining the line between the hegemonic “us” and the subordinated “them” (Lamont and Molnar 2002).

Detailed work traces how collective affiliation among men occurs through the exclusion of women (Bird 1996; Martin 2001). Meanwhile, subordinate men are excluded from the privileges of hegemony through a range of tactics: discredited as “soft” in the “hard” world of international relations, or characterized as hypersexual or too aggressive through racialized discourses (Hooper 2001; Lamont 2000). Homophobic practices, from “fag discourse,” the teasing of boys in school for “sissiness,” to more overt homophobic assaults and murders also serve as processes of exclusion that help cement the boundaries of hegemonic masculinity (Kimmel and Mahler 2003; Messerschmidt 2000; Pascoe 2007; Tomsen 2002). These exclusions target sexual, racial, and ethnic minorities, stretching across national boundaries to exclude men in developing countries (Braun 2011; Heath 2003; Savran 1998). By tracing the ways hegemonic masculinity is constructed through the policing of men and the discrediting of women, this literature highlights the power and efficiency of hegemonic categories.

Recent reformulations of masculinity indicate, however, that hegemonic processes are far from self-reproducing (Connell and Messerschmidt 2005). Men’s attempts at “identity work” are an ongoing project characterized by ambiguity and tension (Thompson and McHugh 1990). Masculine identities have to be constantly constructed, negotiated, and achieved in routine social interactions (Kerfoot and Knights 1993). Attempts at consolidating hegemonic masculinities are thus open to challenge, and require considerable effort to reproduce (Collinson and Hearn 1994). Although this point was made in early theorizations of hegemonic masculinity, empirical analysis of masculinity has tended to neglect the frailty of hegemonic constructs while accentuating their authority and cohesiveness (Connell 1987).

Challenges to hegemony may arise from the simple fact that there is no single masculinity, but a multiplicity of masculinities (Poynting, Noble, and Tabar 1999; Schrock and Schwalbe 2009). Even ostensibly homogenous environments house a diversity of masculine forms (Higate 2003; Ishii-Kuntz 2003). Within any given “type” of masculinity, researchers have found a multitude of social divisions (Gutmann 1996). Masculinity comprises numerous meanings and bridges conflicts that arise at the intersections of sexuality, gender, and race (Archer 2001; Mora 2012; Ross 1998; Wilkins 2012). Given the empirical multiplicity of masculine identities, one has to wonder about the effects of hegemonic consolidation for organizational goals. If hegemonic

masculinity is produced through exclusion, how do men with alternative conceptions of masculinity react to institutionalized attempts at “collective” identity formation? Do subordinate men rebel or reject hegemonic constructs? If men do rebel, what are the effects of their rebellions on organized action? Finally, what do these overlooked insubordinations tell us about existing sociological theories of masculinity?

To answer these questions, I turn to two other bodies of work, the first within gender studies and the second in the arena of new social movements. Destabilizing notions of boundaries as self-enclosed, recent scholarship on gender shows how identities are permeable and closely intertwined processes that need to be studied in relation to each other (Choo and Ferree 2010). Race, class, and gender form a “matrix of domination” or a “complex inequality” (Collins 1990; McCall 2001). Studying these phenomena as linked, feminists use an approach that is alternatively called “integrative,” “race-class-gender,” or “intersectional” (Crenshaw 1991; Glenn 2002; Pascale 2007).

While intersectional approaches question the internal coherence of categorical identities, literature in the new social movements highlights the organizational dangers of ignoring these internal differences (Ferree and Roth 1998). As “agreed upon definitions of membership, boundaries, and activities for the group,” collective identities can pose risks for social movement organizations (Polletta and Jasper 2001). While they are necessary for making claims in the context of interest-group politics, collective identities simultaneously produce other forms of abjection and oppression (Clawson 2003; Gamson 1997; Hearn 1996). By creating categories of difference, institutionalizing exclusion and discrimination, and giving voice to certain oppressions while silencing others the “boundary work” inherent to identity formation can end up undermining the very solidarity it is meant to foster (Phelan 1993). Exclusionary solidarity, solidarity based on an identity of “sameness,” may cause conflict within organizations, constraining movement success (Ackelsberg 1996; Kurtz 2002).

I build on intersectional analysis and work in new social movements to theorize the limits of hegemonic masculinity. In this article, organizational efforts at using masculinity for collective purposes proceeded through traditional mechanisms of exclusion. These mechanisms did not, however, achieve their intended consequences. As scholars of masculinity might expect, VFJ leaders constructed a hegemonic masculinity of brotherhood through constant boundary work, excluding women and men who espoused alternative notions of masculine comportment. Instead of achieving hegemony, however, these exclusions elicited criticism and defection. This case study shows how exclusionary tactics can destabilize the formation of hegemonic masculinity and interrupt the collective action it is meant to inspire.

Institutions may “recruit” individuals to coherent gendered identities by mobilizing a range of discursive strategies and by imposing sanctions and rewards. Simultaneously, however, individuals exercise a certain amount of choice over their decision to adopt or reject any given identity. Identities need to resonate, both emotionally and cognitively, for people to enlist (Adams and Padamsee 2001). And while people’s abilities to reject institutional identities are greatly conditioned by their social background, this process is also shaped by their degree of autonomy from the given institution. For organizations like VFJ that command relatively few resources, preside over an ethnically and occupationally segregated base, and where participation is neither obligatory nor a guarantee of benefits, lack of resonance may easily lead to withdrawal. In contexts such as this, attempts to collectively orient men around a hegemonic masculinity may do more harm than good, undermining solidarity and disrupting mobilization.

Methodology and Research Context

The analysis offered here is based on ten months of participant observation and 30 semi-structured interviews with a racially heterogeneous and occupationally segmented labor force in New York City: street vendors. I used an extended case methodology to understand what

the particularities of one organizational context revealed about existing theories of masculinity (Burawoy 1998). Qualitative interviews added a specifically feminist lens to the extended case method by allowing me to hear voices that were normally marginalized or silenced within the organization. By interviewing people who occupied different positions within VFJ, I heard perspectives from multiple standpoints (Harding 2003; Hekman 1997). An intersectional analysis helped me understand how collective identity formation was complicated by the coconstitution of race, class, and gender within my research site (McCall 2005).

Operating out of a one-room office under the umbrella of a larger nonprofit, VFJ provided legal aid and policy advocacy for New York City's street vendors. VFJ clinics educated vendors about their legal rights, while organizing drives mobilized vendors against the state's regulatory practices. In addition, systemic advocacy raised awareness among both policy makers and the public about the important role of street vendors in the city. After ten years of working in the vending community, the organization had a base of 700 members, making it one of the largest and relatively well-known street vendors' organizations in the city. Three features of this organizational context are noteworthy for the analysis provided in this article. VFJ was resource poor, it was a voluntary organization in the sense that members were not obliged to participate, and it comprised an ethnically diverse and occupationally segregated membership base.

Financed through small grants and membership dues that amounted to \$100 per person annually, VFJ heavily relied on biannual fundraising events to pay its staff and keep its office open. VFJ's limited resources shaped the organization's relationship to its membership base in a number of ways. First, the organization had to rely on the voluntary, unpaid efforts of its board members to organize meetings and build community. If board members failed to complete necessary tasks, staff members could only resort to moral sanctions. Second, staff members were overburdened with work, slowing down the process whereby individual members could contest tickets in court.

For members, the material benefits associated with participating in the organization were thus frequently delayed. The possibility that VFJ organized rallies would create changes to the vending code and law enforcement policy was even more distant. Like board members, members faced little to no punishment for failing to participate other than public shaming. Ultimately, members could withdraw at any time since VFJ was after all a voluntary organization.

Internally, VFJ was organized into three tiers: the executive director and full-time staff, board members, and members. This organizational structure mapped on to decision-making authority within the organization. Samuel, the executive director, founded VFJ and had the final say on what happened within the organization. A middle-class white man in his late thirties with a law degree, Samuel had become interested in vendors while himself working as a vendor for a short time in his youth. Alongside Samuel, VFJ had a community organizer, another lawyer, and a part-time consultant. Like Samuel, both the lawyer and the part-time consultant were white and middle class.

Below the executive director and permanent staff, VFJ's board comprised a rotating group of elected members who served as *de facto* leaders within the organization. During the time of this study, VFJ's board had 11 people, and its composition was relatively representative of the larger membership base in terms of gender and ethnicity. Three of the board members were women, while the rest were men. In terms of ethnicity, three members were African American, one white, two Senegalese, one Hispanic, two Bangladeshi, and two Egyptian. The board was, however, unrepresentative of the membership base in one highly significant way. Board members were financially among the top income earners in the organization. In fact, Samuel explicitly encouraged financially stable members to run for board elections, anticipating that they would have more time to dedicate to the organization. As a result, VFJ's leadership—the 11-member board along with its 3 staff members—occupied a financial position that significantly differed from the membership base. This relative affluence ended up being consequential for the type of brotherhood leaders promoted, one that emphasized a notion of masculinity based on invincibility and strength while ignoring the material vulnerabilities many members faced.

The heterogeneity of VFJ's members reflected the demographic patterns within the broader vending community in New York City. The majority of VFJ members, like the majority of street vendors in New York City, were men. Women comprised roughly 20 percent of the membership base according to my calculations (roughly 15 percent of NYC vendors are female). Similarly, VFJ's members also mirrored the ethnic and racial composition of the vending community.² VFJ's members hailed from four regions of the world: West Africa (Senegal and Mauritania), the Middle East (Egypt), Bangladesh, and the United States.

As in the larger NYC vending population, ethnic cleavages within VFJ mapped on to occupational niches, which in turn entailed dramatic differences in income.³ Vending licenses dictate everything from what vendors can or cannot sell, where they can conduct business, to the precise measurement of their cart. Since many vendors enter the trade through ethnically based social networks, vendors of any given ethnic group tend to hold the same kind of vending license. The majority of Bangladeshi and Egyptians, for example, work as food vendors while West Africans dominate the market in both illegal and legal general merchandise, selling t-shirts and purses. African Americans and whites are far more likely to work as art vendors, selling posters, books, and music.

As a result of these occupational niches, West African members of VFJ, those most likely to be vending illegally without a license, tended to be at the lower end of the income spectrum. Bangladeshi fruit and vegetable vendors were not that much better off. The highest income earners included American-born art vendors, and a handful of Bangladeshi, Egyptian, and West Africans who had managed to break out of their ethnic group's occupational niche. These overlapping ethnic and occupational differences proved to be immensely consequential for how men within VFJ understood masculinity, and responded to organizational efforts to build brotherhood.

For a period of ten months, I attended monthly board and bimonthly membership meetings at VFJ, and participated in VFJ's conferences with other state and civil society organizations. My ethnography covered VFJ's publicity and fundraising events, street demonstrations and protests, confrontations with the Green Market, and community board meetings. Every week, I volunteered part time at the VFJ office, and observed how members interacted with VFJ leaders, and with each other.

Participant observation was supplemented by 30 semistructured interviews, including all 11 board members, the executive director, 1 outside consultant, and 17 members. These interviews ran anywhere from one to four hours, and were either conducted over coffee, or at vendors' carts during off-peak hours.⁴ I questioned interviewees about their personal histories, and asked them to comment on VFJ and its leadership, including their notions of masculinity and how it relates to brotherhood. I conducted interviews with Bangladeshi vendors in Bengali and translated them into English. All other interviews were conducted in English. In addition to participant observation and interviews, I read VFJ publications to learn more about the membership base.

As a young, educated woman of Indian descent who speaks fluent Bengali, my position as a researcher within VFJ provided me with a fair amount of access and insight into the gender dynamics of the organization. Many of the older male vendors opened up to me relatively easily, possibly seeing me as nonthreatening, whereas the minority group of women within the

2. VFJ had very small numbers of Chinese and Hispanic vendors. Largely, the missing Chinese population had to do with language barriers while Hispanics were drawn to a competing organization in NYC that catered to Spanish speakers.

3. On average, NYC vendors earn approximately \$7,500 per year, placing them among the lowest 9 percent of wage earners in the country. This average, however, hides noticeable internal differences with successful vendors earning upwards of \$50 to \$60,000 from multiple carts.

4. Among the 30 people interviewed, 5 were women (3 of whom were board members and the remaining 2 members), and the remaining 25 were men (9 board members, the executive director, and 15 members). Interviewees also varied according to race: 3 were white (1 man, 2 women); 3 African American (all men); 3 Hispanic (all women); 8 West African (all men); 5 Egyptian (all men); 8 Bangladeshi (all men).

organization seemed to view me as an ally, poking me or rolling their eyes when they were blatantly ignored during group meetings.

For the purposes of this article, however, the most important feature of my experiences with VFJ members had to do with the differential patterns of interaction I had with different groups of men. While my interactions with Egyptian vendors were sexualized, my interactions with Bangladeshi and West African vendors took on familial overtones. Getting winked at, being called “honey” and “baby,” and being stared at were regular features of my encounters with Egyptian vendors. Meanwhile, the Bangladeshis referred to me as “*didi*” (elder sister), and regularly discussed their families with me and asked about mine. While my rapport with Bangladeshi vendors was clearly enabled by our common linguistic and ethnic backgrounds, the surprising fact was that I encountered similar treatment from West African vendors. Those who spoke French often referred to me as “*soeur*” (sister), and avoided sexual innuendo.

My position relative to these three groups of men at VFJ ended up being analytically useful. I found the distinct patterns of sexualization and kinship illustrative of the masculinities that different groups promoted within the organization. The overt heterosexuality of Egyptian vendors mapped on to the notions of youthful militancy, risk taking, and individual financial independence they espoused. Meanwhile, by positioning themselves as my “brothers,” Bangladeshi and West African vendors signaled that their notion of masculinity centered on families and the reciprocity that entailed.

These insights were key to my analytic and theoretical reorientations during the many months I spent in the field. When I first conceived of this research project, I had a number of relatively broad and vague research questions in mind. How did VFJ organize across linguistic and cultural barriers? How did the majority male population shape the gendered dynamics within the movement? Shortly after entering VFJ, I realized that the organization was beset with a number of problems, chief among which was its inability to motivate members around common aims. I then started focusing on the way VFJ leaders and members responded to and potentially produced this situation. During this stage, I wrote extensive field notes and biweekly memos where I attempted to arrange my thoughts into some semblance of coherence. I shared these memos with my colleagues at New York University to see what jumped out at them.

During this process, I noticed that VFJ leaders repeatedly invoked brotherhood in their interactions with one another and with members. This discourse seemed to serve as a bridging mechanism across numerous kinds of difference. I then began to directly ask people what they meant by brotherhood, comparing their statements with each other’s and with those who never mentioned the term. In the process of asking about brotherhood, I started understanding something about a related concept: masculinity. Men within the organization espoused distinctly different notions of what kind of masculinity was normative. I identified three different types, and realized that brotherhood was a composite of two types of masculinity and an explicit rejection of the third. This remainder category became theoretically troubling, leading me back to the literature on hegemonic masculinity and collective action. It revealed how masculinities were intersectional categories, intercepted by classed and raced forms of difference that are neglected at a movement’s peril.

While I foreground how gender construction complicated collective action at VFJ, I do not claim that these processes were by any means “determinative” of movement failures. As previous ethnographic work has highlighted, NYC vendors live in a permanent state of transience, their lives structured by an ongoing struggle with poverty, illegality, and marginalization (Duneier 1999). To make matters worse, vendors also face a rocky regulatory environment (Austin 1994; Lueck 2005). Vendors happen to be the most highly regulated entrepreneurs in New York City. They are purview to a thicket of confusing and contradictory laws (Street Vendor Project 2006). These hurdles make organizing street vendors a challenging business.

In light of these structural conditions, I pose a limited set of claims. First, even if VFJ leaders had rallied members around brotherhood, there is no guarantee that they would have succeeded

at their larger movement goals of reducing fines or ending discriminatory state policies. Second, material constraints were fundamental to the way masculinity was formulated and contested within the organization. In this sense, my “discursive” analysis is keenly aware of the way class relations helped shape the gendered dynamics I observed within VFJ. Brotherhood relied on a notion of masculinity that was already arranged in specific ways to occupational challenges. The rhetoric of masculinity deployed through brotherhood *ignored* the real-life structural constraints many members faced, namely their structural inability to take risks or to act “equal” to those who commanded more resources.

Boundary Work: Constructing a Hegemonic Masculinity

A typical day at VFJ looked something like this: members dropped by to report tickets and police harassment, discussed protest strategies and fundraising ideas, and kept each other abreast of street closures and festivals. References to brotherhood were common in these relatively mundane exchanges. “Hey, what’s up brother?” William, a long time African American member welcomed Juan to a meeting. When Mohammed later interrupted Juan, Samuel cried out, “Hey, listen up. Our brother Juan here is trying to tell us something. Give the man some respect.” During mock altercations between members, those who joined the fray tended to warn the opposing side in similar ways, “Hey step back, that’s my brother you talking to!” Meanwhile, Yusuf, a young Egyptian vendor, tried to initiate a conversation with Amadou, a new Senegalese member: “Grab a chair brother, no need to stay on your feet all day and night!” At the beginning of each membership meeting, Tyron, a long-time African American board member, opened by welcoming new brothers to the group.

While women comprised roughly 20 percent of VFJ’s membership base, and three women served on its board, men in leadership positions envisioned brotherhood as a common identity that bridged ethnic and occupational differences between men. When I asked Samuel, VFJ’s executive director, how members should ideally relate to one another, he argued that brotherhood could unite a heterogeneous membership base: “We have a lot pulling us apart: different languages, religion, race. Also, different kinds of vendors have different issues. So brotherhood can be a powerful thing. It brings everyone together.” As one of the few white men in the organization, Samuel worried that linguistic and racial barriers prevented him from fully connecting with members. By referring to “different kinds of vendors” Samuel alluded to the challenges occupational segregation posed for collective unity.

For Samuel, brotherhood involved specific attributes. Addressing a membership meeting, Samuel fleshed out what he meant by the concept: “We are each other’s brothers. That means we watch out for one another, and fight when needed. The city isn’t going to pay attention to us unless we show a strong front.” By alluding to a “strong front” and the necessity of fighting and “watching out for one another,” Samuel marked brotherhood as a gendered category that involved distinctly masculine virtues associated with fraternity, equality, and militancy.

Echoing Samuel, a number of board members articulated brotherhood as a militant fraternity of equals. When I asked John, the African American board member whose calls for brotherhood opened this article, what brotherhood meant to him, he explained: “You got my back, I got yours. If someone’s helping you out like a brother should, then you keep fighting the good fight.” Likewise, Hamid, a newly elected Egyptian board member, talked about brotherhood by referencing equality and militancy. A tall, handsome man in his fifties, Hamid earned a comfortable income from two hot dog carts. Having introduced a large number of Egyptian vendors to VFJ, Hamid found it relatively easy to command attention. As a result, he frequently addressed membership meetings. Before one particular rally, Hamid attempted to motivate members:

We cannot just think of ourselves. Think of all your brothers in this room. I hear someone say they have a bad leg and can’t go, or their wife is sick. If we are to get anywhere, we all have to do things equal. Brothers fight for each other.

While John indirectly alluded to the relationship between equality and militancy, Hamid more directly connected these two concepts. Within Hamid's address, difference and inequality were compressed into one, and both threatened to undermine collective action.

By emphasizing equality and militancy as manly traits, brotherhood promised to counter the threats that men within the organization faced on the street and at home. Papa, a general vendor who illegally worked in midtown without a license, described how police harassment degraded his sense of manliness. "The police, they'll treat you like a criminal. Someday, we feel real low, hardly like a man." Meanwhile, Amjad, who worked seven days a week at his halal food cart in midtown, admitted that his job created tensions within his family: "My wife wants me to be home more. But how can I? I can tell she is disappointed. This isn't the right job for a man like me. The family I come from, I should have become a doctor. Instead I am on the street." Acutely sensing the relationship between work and masculinity, Amjad articulated how his job on the street made him look like the wrong kind of man to his family. Lacking the professional credentials and status that go along with medicine, Amjad strove to inform his work with a sense of professionalism by donning a chef's hat and an immaculately starched apron. These practices were not just marketing tools, but also a means of recuperating a sense of masculine pride.

Malik, a Senegalese board member, alluded to the ways brotherhood could help counter these threats. Reminiscing about the past, he admitted that he had partly become dedicated to VFJ because the organization helped him regain a sense of manly dignity:

On the street, always same thing: police push you around, customer no want something. It was different here [at VFJ]. Samuel says we are brothers. I think this is right idea. You feel, I am a man, I do something, help others.

Through his own life history, Malik highlighted how brotherhood recast members' self-definitions, helping them psychologically cope with the obstacles they faced at work so they could feel like men again.

For Malik, Papa, and Amjad, a gendered identity based on brotherhood helped VFJ steer around resource constraints and internal divisions between vendors to create a sense of self-worth and collective unity. Brotherhood within VFJ thus ostensibly functioned in the way collective identities work within a range of social movements, redefining personal experiences in terms of collective grievances (Melucci 2003; Taylor and Whittier 1999). As noted by existing scholarship, gendered identifications within social movements often arise within a crisis of masculinity, and VFJ is no different (Maynard 1989). Brotherhood took men who felt belittled by their experiences at work and helped them learn how to be "strong," independent, and "fight the good fight."

While brotherhood thus served as a promise for otherwise marginalized men, it was constructed through the systematic exclusion and silencing of women. Women were excluded from the boundaries of brotherhood at critical organizational events. Hamid entered the April board meeting late and everyone turned to shake his hand, while Samuel filled him in on the proceedings. Triunfa came in shortly after Hamid, but nobody acknowledged her entrance. The difference in reception was notable given that Triunfa had been a board member longer than Hamid, and continuously demonstrated her dedication to the organization by staying late after meetings to do photocopying and cleanup.

Like Triunfa, other women within the organization felt the effects of exclusion. When Jane, a long-term board member, got run over by a taxi and stopped attending meetings, her inactivity largely went unnoticed. Contrast the board's response to Jane's injuries with Darren's a month later. When Darren, a retired soldier, fell and twisted his bad ankle, Samuel immediately brought his injuries to everyone's attention. A number of other board members, including Fallou, a wealthy Senegalese vendor, suggested that VFJ should "help a brother in need." I was surprised that so much effort was put into ensuring Darren's return since he had never struck me as especially hard working. Meanwhile, Jane always took on the responsibility of reminding members about

upcoming meetings, and single-handedly organized VFJ's holiday fundraiser. Despite my assessment of their relative merits, Darren was promptly sent a \$250 check along with a fruit basket, while Jane languished in the hospital unattended.

These more overt exclusions punctuated a day-to-day environment where women and women's contributions went unacknowledged. Men frequently occupied the center of the office, their conversations volubly impinging on anybody who walked by. Women rarely talked publicly. Their conversations were housed in nooks and crannies, in front of the drinking fountain, next to the copy machine. The spatial centrality of men's voices and interpersonal relations was no coincidence. Their voice was an artifact of an organizational culture that gave precedence to particular bodies and gendered practices. These exchanges attempted to establish brotherhood as the hegemonic model for masculine comportment within the organization, using boundary work between men and women to recruit men's allegiance.

John taught a new Bangladeshi member a special handshake meant for brothers. Meanwhile, Hamid, a recently elected board member, and one of the more successful Egyptian vendors in the organization, shook hands with all the men when he entered the room, and became confused when I extended my hand towards him. Specialized bodily practices and discourses marked men as brothers. Like the other women within the organization, I was excluded from brotherhood's jocular exchanges. For men traversing the office floor towards other men, women's bodies proved to be pieces of furniture to be awkwardly avoided.

VFJ leaders' responses to members and to each other allude to the ways brotherhood differentiated men from women, endowing men with a collective sense of superiority. Clearly, the boundary work involved in these negotiations helped motivate some men within the organization, just as scholars of hegemonic masculinity might expect. Faced with external threats to their masculinity, men like Malik, Papa, and Amjad felt affirmed by the organization's discursive strategies and motivated to be active within it. But they did not represent everybody. Many men within the organization did not react well to brotherhood. The next section examines the reasons behind their responses.

Interpretive Disagreements: Masculinity as an Intersectional Category

Using overt boundary work between men and women, brotherhood promised to unify men under a hegemonic notion of masculinity connected to equality and militancy. In reality, the category was far from universally appealing. Members responded to brotherhood through three disparate notions of masculinity, shaped by the intersections of gender, class, and ethnicity within their lives. By emphasizing equality and militancy, brotherhood did not appeal to those who interpreted manhood through alternative tropes of familial responsibility and mutual care.

Conversations about brotherhood quickly morphed into discussions of masculinity at large. Tyron, the long-standing African American board member who always opened membership meetings by welcoming new brothers to the fold, was a well-educated, financially successful art vendor. During a long interview at his cart in Harlem, I began to understand how Tyron's approach to brotherhood was shaped by his larger anxieties about masculine conduct. Discussing his training in civil rights and the student movement of the sixties, Tyron explained:

For black men in this country, it used be that you were a boy. Well now, you have the option of being a man, of being equal to any other man. But how do you get there? You got to have some support, but the kind that raises you up. Not the kind that makes you dependent.

In this conceptualization, masculinity is situated within the racialized history of the United States, where black men were treated as boys. Dependency emerges as a critical threat to manhood, and equality its counterpoint. When Tyron argued that men needed "support," he conceptualized an organizational vision for VFJ as an institution that could help men be men by treating them

equally. In his actions towards other men in the organization, Tyron was soft-spoken, always polite, and never domineering. In turn, he rarely accepted excuses for missed meetings, asking everyone to participate equally in the organization's success.

Tyron's vision of masculinity as equality existed alongside a second conceptualization of masculinity that floated around VFJ. This notion of masculinity highlighted militancy and aggression. Khaled, an Egyptian vendor who ran a successful Halal food cart, expressed disdain for men who refused to join a protest against fine increases. When I wondered if an alternative strategy would have won more votes, Khaled dismissed my reasoning as misguided. For Khaled, the real problem was that some men were "cowardly," while others were not. "Cowards" always found some kind of excuse, backing out at the last minute: "Some people are weak. They get scared by cold weather. If you're strong, this is no problem. You are always ready to join." Given that some men were simply cowardly, Khaled believed that VFJ needed to forge ahead with whatever strategy the leadership felt was best. In a membership meeting, Khaled took the floor to say as much, confirming that brotherhood involved a community of "strong" men. A group of young Egyptian vendors cheered Khaled's speech. Winking at Stacy and me, the youngest women in the room, they enthusiastically added their names to the rally sign-up sheet while circling the room exuding a sense of virile militancy.

Together, Tyron and Khaled articulated notions of masculinity that mapped on to the internal components of brotherhood. But VFJ also housed a third discourse of masculinity, one that emphasized alternative values of familial responsibility and mutual care. This third interpretation was apparent in a series of statements. Ibrahim, a Senegalese vendor who sold purses in midtown, described his commitments as a husband and father. "Everything I got goes to my wife. I have two children." Likewise, Kumar, a South Indian vendor, admitted that he frequently felt exhausted and disheartened by his occupation, but forced himself to keep going because it was his responsibility as a breadwinner.

These men's alternative rhetoric about masculinity shaped their responses to brotherhood. During our conversation at his fruit and vegetable cart, Farid, a Bangladeshi man in his mid-fifties argued that brotherhood involved financial responsibility.

In our country, a brother is someone who takes care of you. I had no brother of my own, so these two boys I grew up with, they were my brothers. They even helped me raise money for my sister's wedding . . . Boys in our village were just that way. You know how it is, we were raised to feel responsible for our families, and we all did projects around the village. There was a real communal spirit.

Farid began answering my question about brotherhood by strictly talking about brothers as financial providers. His vision of brotherhood, however, was based on a more generalized picture of how boys "were" and "were raised," about the normative dimensions of masculinity at large. Like Ibrahim and Kumar, Farid understood manhood as financial responsibility and mutual care, not only towards one's family but also to the larger community. As someone who was ostensibly raised in a similar cultural setting, I, the Bengali researcher, was expected to "know how it is."

One board member went so far as to try and incorporate these alternative elements into the brotherhood promoted at VFJ. Anwar, a Bangladeshi board member who sold hot dogs in front of Ground Zero, staunchly believed that VFJ needed to do more to take care of its neediest members. Arguing that organizing by itself would not protect vendors who were facing financial collapse, Anwar initiated an "Emergency Fund." Towards the end of each meeting, members were asked to voluntarily donate as much as they wanted to the fund, which would then be made available to anyone who needed immediate financial assistance.

But Anwar's attempts to transform brotherhood were overwhelmed by other leaders' concerted efforts to limit the identity to equality and militancy. As a result, the discourse of masculinity as familial responsibility and mutual care frequently came into conflict with brotherhood, challenging its commitments. At the end of a discussion about future protest strategies, I trailed a group of Senegalese vendors out of the office on to the subway. Once out of earshot of VFJ leaders, several of them admitted feeling uncomfortable with the protest, arguing that it might

threaten their ability to earn a stable income. Moussa, a middle-aged man with three children and a stay-at-home wife, asked the following question: "Tell me, if I have to do something that harms my family, should I do it?" At that particular moment, Moussa felt he had to choose between two contradictory notions of masculinity: the hegemonic model put forward by VFJ under the rubric of brotherhood and his own conceptualization of himself as a good husband and father.

VFJ members' distinct conceptualizations of masculinity were far from random or haphazard. Discourses around manhood emerged at the intersections of gender, race, and class with these men's lives. Each of the three rhetorics appealed to different groups of men systematically on the basis of cultural history and occupational social networks. In the case of vendors, where race and ethnicity generally determine what type of license a vendor holds, these two categories frequently overlapped.

Bangladeshi vendors were prone to define masculinity around financial responsibility and care out of a combination of cultural and occupational factors. Bangladeshis tended to be lifetime vendors, supporting large extended families. They were frequently primary breadwinners, citing the "culture" of their homeland for why none of their wives worked for wages. In line with Farid's memories of the way boys in his village financially provided for their families, most of the Bangladeshi men I interviewed contributed to an extended family. These habituated practices in turn shaped how Bangladeshi vendors evaluated and responded to brotherhood.

Financial responsibility and its twin, financial dependence, did not simply arise from cultural expectations. These values shaped Bangladeshi vending networks within New York. Anwar did not initiate the Emergency Fund simply out of benevolence, but because it served as a patronage system that ensured other Bangladeshi vendors' respect. On several occasions, Anwar directed Bangladeshi vendors in need of short-term loans to Stacy, the person who managed the fund. These vendors in turn frequently told me how grateful they were to Anwar. When the Green Market displaced Anwar's cart from Zuccotti Square, he was able to gather a large group of Bangladeshi followers who supported his public petition to the community board. When the petition failed, Anwar's life became increasingly precarious. Basing his masculinity around notions of financial responsibility thus made sense for Anwar on multiple levels, for he himself was not above the material solace such an ethic could provide.

VFJ leaders' insistence on militancy and equality also proved to be a risky commitment for West African vendors like Ibrahim and Moussa. Ironically, inequality provided insurance against the precarious nature of their daily lives. Of the eight men I talked to who had migrated from West Africa, six were operating without a license, an unsurprising fact given that nearly 80 percent of unlicensed vendors surveyed in New York come from West Africa. Unlicensed vendors tended to operate under the jurisdiction of more established vendors with licenses. These networks both kept West African vendors afloat, and enmeshed them in webs of dependence and hierarchy. Given the degree to which these external relationships governed their precarious lives, West African vendors found it difficult to envision their masculinity as equal or aggressive. Their very membership within VFJ usually depended on the patronage and well wishes of leaders within their communities, men who were frequently responsible for introducing them to the organization in the first place. Voicing dissent against these community leaders, or acting in ways that intimidated that they thought of themselves as "equals" could spell financial suicide in the outside world.

Meanwhile, emphasizing familial responsibility proved to be a less compelling basis for masculinity among VFJ's African American men. Tyron, Michael, Darren, and John were not primary breadwinners in their families. Darren worked intermittently, while his girlfriend held a steady job in retail. In his eyes, brotherhood thus had less to do with men's financial responsibility towards women, and more to do with equality between men of different races. All three of these men had histories with organized action and civil disobedience in the United States. These histories formatively shaped their notions of brotherhood. Tyron was involved in the student movements of the 60s, while Darren and John used to work in unionized factories. They situated brotherhood within a discourse of equality and civil rights because it promised to restore the civil freedoms historically denied to men of color in the United States.

African American vendors' call for equality worked well alongside Egyptian vendors' emphasis on militancy. Through the practice of "license burning," using vending licenses to rapidly amass a large amount of money over a short period of time by violating laws and refusing to pay tickets, many of the Egyptian members of VFJ used vending as a temporary means to some other more permanent occupation. Meanwhile, older Egyptians within the organization, men like Hamid, tended to be relatively affluent. Having lower stakes in the game because they were young and occupationally mobile, or because they are financially well established, the Egyptians within VFJ were more likely to advocate a brotherhood based on aggressive notions of masculine comportment.

While ethnicity and occupational networks thus largely overlapped for VFJ members, a handful of men stepped outside the gendered scripts of their ethnic groups. On one side of the divide, Senegalese men like Fallou and Cisse and Bangladeshi men like Hassan opted out of the notions of masculinity espoused by other vendors from their countries of origin. Fallou, the youngest of the three, spoke impeccable English and earned most of his money not from vending, but from distributing clothing that had been made in Bangladesh to other West African vendors in New York. Like Fallou, Cisse had also managed to move up the vending food chain by opening a convenience store. Meanwhile, Hassan, an upwardly mobile Bangladeshi vendor, ran a lucrative food cart in Midtown where he employed four other Bangladeshi men from his village. Unlike other Bangladeshi and Senegalese vendors, all three of these men articulated brotherhood as a community of equals. Positioned at the top of the vending class ladder, they were relatively autonomous from the social networks that bound other men from their countries.

On the other side of the divide, Freddy, a young Egyptian vendor, came to espouse notions of masculinity based on familial responsibility when his circumstances changed. Having fallen in love with a working-class American woman who regularly ate lunch at his hot dog cart, Freddy moved from being a proponent of militancy to advocating a more protectionist form of brotherhood: "The guys here, they just need help sometimes. When you are young, you don't get how serious the situation is. It's really a survival thing. If you have a family to support, you can't be taking too many risks." It was clear that Freddy's new aspirations, to get married and support a family in New York, had radically changed his ideas about masculinity. As a result, he began to espouse very different notions about what kind of brotherhood was appropriate to VFJ.

Freddy's repositioning towards brotherhood highlights the complex processes underlying the formulation of and contestation over masculinity among VFJ members. Members ascribed to three distinct notions of masculinity, only two of which were articulated within brotherhood. Ignoring the way masculinity is an intersectional category, VFJ leaders continued to pursue their hegemonic project, failing to see how intersectional identities could shape conflicting responses to brotherhood. Despite such denial, members' cultural backgrounds and material realities shaped how they normatively approached brotherhood, spelling an ongoing battle between men about what it meant to be a man.

Organizational Disruptions: From Exclusion to Alienation and Disunity

By excluding those who connected masculinity to familial responsibility and care and insisting on brotherhood instead, VFJ's leaders undermined their own collective aspirations. Brotherhood disrupted solidarity in three key ways. First, and least surprisingly, it alienated women, depriving the organization of their input. Second, it alienated men, by making VFJ leaders look insensitive and myopic. Last, it fueled contestation and enmity between those who remained, silencing alternative organizing strategies that may have appealed to a broader base.

As much of the existing literature on hegemonic masculinity would predict, brotherhood systematically excluded women. All three of the women who served on the board during my time at VFJ left the organization, complaining of feeling ignored and slighted. When I visited Jane after she was run over by a taxi, she bitterly commented that VFJ had forgotten about her when

she needed the organization the most. She explained, “Nobody wants to keep working without getting the recognition they deserve.” Shortly after Jane’s departure, Stacy withdrew from the board. She told me privately that she felt pushed into doing work for men in the organization who claimed the credit. She specifically sighted Anwar’s pet project, the Emergency Fund, as something she had been forced into managing. Triunfa was the last of the women to leave. Before her departure, she mentioned that she no longer felt her presence was needed at VFJ. I interpreted Triunfa’s feelings of uselessness to be integrally connected to the organization’s singular lack of recognition of her contributions.

These women’s departures exacted serious costs on the organization. Triunfa had helped grease the day-to-day activities at VFJ, voluntarily cleaning the office, making photocopies, and notifying members of upcoming meetings. After she left, many of these duties were neglected, and members regularly complained about not being notified about meetings. Stacy’s departure signaled a halt to VFJ’s mediation with the Times Square Alliance. A network of businesses that had historically been hostile to street vendors, the Alliance had been inching towards more progressive policies through meetings with VFJ board members. This relationship unraveled after Stacy left. While Triunfa’s exit took a toll on daily life at VFJ and Stacy’s departure jeopardized external relationships, Jane’s withdrawal from the organization rang the death knell of that year’s holiday fundraising season. Before her accident, Jane had designed a plan to raise money by selling tins full of candied nuts. When she withdrew from the board, nobody took over the project. Stacked in the corner of the office, the empty tins made a hollow clanging sound when anybody accidentally bumped into them.

Brotherhood not only alienated women, but also made the organization appear ineffectual to particular men. Ibrahim, the Senegalese vendor who highlighted his commitments to his family, characterized brotherhood as a fictitious category with little relevance to his life. Explaining why he did not wish to participate in VFJ protests, Ibrahim directly critiqued brotherhood for setting up unrealistic expectations: “They say we brothers. But what it mean? They say do this, do that, but how can I do? I don’t got no license.” Referencing the third notion of masculinity that was prevalent at VFJ, a notion of manhood connected to familial obligations, Ibrahim argued that his first priority was being a stable breadwinner. To the extent that brotherhood threatened that stability by putting him in risky situations during protests, Ibrahim rejected the identity and the organizational context that demanded such action.

Like Ibrahim, Mohit, a Bangladeshi vendor in his late thirties, critiqued brotherhood for insisting on equality, while ignoring real material differences between men. Not owning his own cart, Mohit eked out a meager living by working part time at other vendors’ carts throughout the city. A long-term member of VFJ, Mohit expressed little interest in being brothers with relatively affluent men in the organization:

He [Samuel] tells me we are brothers and that we are the same. How can we be the same? He’s a lawyer! I’m a poor man from Sylhet [a district in Bangladesh]. He doesn’t have a family. I have to think of my mother. My brothers are still in school.

Mohit identified himself as a brother, but pointed out that his real brothers were back in Bangladesh. Pretending to be Samuel’s brother only occluded the vast class differences that divided them.

Critiquing VFJ’s insistence on militancy, Mohit went on to complain that VFJ didn’t “really do anything” for its members:

There are other organizations that help vendors secure spots [on the street]. They even give their members loans to buy carts. These guys [VFJ] don’t do any of that. What good does it do to always be protesting and organizing strikes?

Mohit gestured at the ways brotherhood ignored his most immediate material interests: attaining his own cart and securing a spot. Linking VFJ’s discursive commitments to its institutional

practices, Mohit rationalized his decision to stop attending organizational events. Samuel lamented Mohit's absence because he had once been an active member. Unfortunately, Samuel blamed Mohit's disappearance on his "bad attitude," ignoring the substantial ways brotherhood had failed to address Mohit's daily challenges.

Finally, brotherhood disrupted unity by breeding constant conflict between men. Tensions erupted within the office whenever either component of brotherhood, equality or militancy, were threatened. During the course of my research, a group of Bangladeshi vendors vocally advocated for a service that would help members pay fines. The campaign was unsurprising given Bangladeshi vendors' tendency to emphasize financial responsibility as a key tenet of masculinity. Before his departure from VFJ, Mohit played a central role within the movement. VFJ leaders, however, were clearly uncomfortable with the service. Anxious about preserving "equality" between men, Tyron feared that fine reimbursements would introduce distinctions between members. Meanwhile, John worried that reimbursements would undermine militancy, transforming VFJ into a service organization and making members into clients. While financial responsibility and mutual care were positive markers of manhood for men like Mohit, these practices threatened the masculine boundaries of brotherhood as defined by the organization. In the end, the voices of board members like John and Tyron overruled Mohit's.

Financial "dependence" posed such a threat to brotherhood, it bred hostility between board members. When Anwar first initiated the Emergency Fund, VFJ's other leaders seemed supportive. But as the fund grew through generous contributions from members, the board was unable to agree on when or who to distribute it to. Many board members worried it might "send the wrong signal," indicating that VFJ would bail out irresponsible vendors at any given moment. Anwar was incensed by the blockade, making several attempts to have the funds released. By the end of my eight months at VFJ, Anwar's earlier enthusiasm about the organization had visibly diminished and the fund remained undisbursed.

Brotherhood not only caused conflict by denying members' financial needs, but also by demanding that men engage in perilous practices. Amadou's expulsion from the organization provided a stark example of the way brotherhood alienated men by placing them at risk while casting them as cowardly when they rebelled. Amadou's estrangement began with an attempt to organize a protest in front of city hall. The "24-hour vigil," which involved rotating shifts of two vendors for an indefinite period of time, intended to force the mayor to reassess the city's fine structure. Despite VFJ leaders' attempts to rally members under the banner of brotherhood during the organizing meeting, Bangladeshi and Senegalese vendors defected from the campaign.

Amadou, a new board member, made the mistake of publicly agreeing with the Bangladeshis and Senegalese. Two days later, he became the focus of an emergency board meeting. Samuel opened the meeting by addressing Amadou in a seemingly apologetic, but largely accusatory fashion.

I lost my temper. But you know who I was mad at? I was mad at you [Amadou]. You were supposed to be leading your Senegalese brothers, but you said you didn't want to fight. You were afraid! If a board member is afraid, all our brothers are going to be afraid too.

By framing Amadou as "afraid," Samuel bypassed the real issue: that Amadou simply disagreed with the adopted strategy, not necessarily with the idea of direct action itself.

Responding to Samuel, Amadou reasoned that the campaign would have created a high-risk situation by isolating shifts of two people. In essence, VFJ was asking individual members to protest without the strength of a group behind them: "You out there at night by yourself. Maybe the police come and lock you up. You never know. They take your stuff and lock you up." Amadou's personal experiences revealed that the police could and did behave in arbitrary ways. The previous year, Amadou had been arrested when he tried to document police harassment by taking a photograph. The police had handcuffed him, citing New York's post-9/11 anti-terrorist laws. After spending a night in jail and losing a portion of his savings on bail, Amadou remained concerned about individual forms of protest.

While Amadou tried to communicate his reservations about the particular strategy involved, his remarks were chided as “unbrotherly” by a number of board members. John remarked, “brothers don’t sell each other out like that,” intimating that Amadou had betrayed the brotherhood through his dissent. In a more gentle tone, Cisse reasoned that the board had to set an example of the “bonds that united them.” When Amadou rose from his chair to leave, other men on the board agreed that the organization would be better off without him. That was the last time anybody saw Amadou at VFJ.

Amadou’s expulsion from the board cost the organization more than a board member. Amadou had served as a contact point between VFJ and other West African vendors on his block. When he dropped out of the organization, these men followed suit. More fundamentally, Amadou’s expulsion took place within a context where his voice was not the only one to be silenced. The 24-hour-vigil fell apart because those who insisted on equality and militancy refused to accommodate other men’s concerns. Instead, these concerns were classified as cowardly and summarily rejected for being unbefitting to brotherly conduct.

A similar set of events transpired a few months after Amadou left. Once again, VFJ leaders’ insistence on brotherhood fueled tension between men within the organization. This time, conflict erupted after the board attempted to resuscitate the aborted 24-hour vigil. Despite the earlier skirmish with Amadou and opposition from Bangladeshi and Senegalese, the particularities of the campaign strategy remained unchanged. The plan was, once again, to hold an around-the-clock vigil with rotating shifts of two vendors. Only the venue had changed. Instead of city hall, the vigil would now take place in front of the mayor’s house.

A number of Bangladeshi members immediately voiced opposition. Given that it was now the dead of winter, they were reluctant to support a strategy that would expose participants to sub-zero nightly temperatures. Ali, a young and energetic vendor who worked near Canal Street, spoke on behalf of other Bangladeshis. Ali’s questions were immediately cut short. “Why don’t you just admit you’re afraid man?” Darren aggressively asked him. The retired soldier who had been sent a \$250 check after twisting his knee, Darren frequently played a key role in policing the boundaries of brotherhood. VFJ’s other leaders rarely silenced him, profitably using his intimidation tactics to contain dissenting men. When Ali did not answer, John joined in, chastising him. “Listen this strategy takes guts. You’ve got to step up to the plate brother, know what I mean?” Ali sat down and did not speak for the rest of the meeting. A patchy schedule was drawn up for the vigil as members were forced to sign their names to eight-hour shifts.

Before he voiced reservations about the campaign, other men in the organization had commended Ali for his dynamism. When I talked to Ali on the way out of the meeting, he expressed dismay about the way he had been treated at VFJ: “I don’t agree with them, so I’m afraid? They say we’re brothers, but it’s like having a bad brother—the kind that hits you when you do something he doesn’t like!” Ali questioned the boundaries of brotherhood. In the process of forming a collectivity, men at VFJ exerted punitive sanctions on other men.

Once again, VFJ’s leaders ignored dissent, barreling ahead with their own strategy while rationalizing their choices through a discourse of brotherhood. The night before the protest, everything once again fell apart. The first two shifts, manned largely by Bangladeshi vendors, had withdrawn from the protest. By nine the next morning, I was sitting in Samuel’s studio apartment with a small number of demoralized board members. Amadou and Jane had already left the organization by this point. Triunfa and Stacy were on their way out. The remaining board members desperately brainstormed next steps. Without the first two shifts, the 24-hour vigil could hardly get under way. In the end, a bedraggled and confused group walked to the mayor’s house to deliver a giant sheet cake with “Please remember us” scrawled in pink loopy letters across the top. The cake failed to make it past the doorman and ended up collecting raindrops as it waited inspection for traces of poison.

Amadou’s and Ali’s interactions with the organization signal the ways brotherhood not only undermined solidarity by breeding conflict between men, but more broadly created an organizational culture where certain strategies were deemed more masculine despite their strategic value.

Instead of recruiting members' allegiance, brotherhood necessitated a series of exclusions that undermined collective identity formation and the solidarity it was intended to create.

Conclusion

The men and women in this study reflect a select group of workers. Their stories do not, however, fit neatly into existing theories of hegemonic masculinity, and therefore necessitate a reanalysis. While gender scholars have argued that hegemonic masculinity enables collective action through a series of exclusionary mechanisms that define "us" from "them," this article shows how exclusion undermines hegemonic aspirations, even for men. Members' disparate interpretations of masculinity, based on the intersections of ethnicity, culture, and the material conditions surrounding specific occupational niches, created ongoing contestation over the boundaries of appropriate masculine behavior within the organization. Instead of eliciting cooperation and allegiance, the discourse of brotherhood alienated men and women, undermining solidarity and constraining collective action.

This case study makes two overarching points. First, it demonstrates how hegemonic masculinity can be a perilous social movement strategy. Second, it details the specific organizational contexts where collective gender identities may pose the greatest risks. The organizational disruptions that grew from brotherhood at VFJ indicate that discursive choices around gender matter for organizing. Overly exclusionary constructs can be hazardous. Rather than operating to homogenize men, brotherhood subverted organizational attempts. In and of itself, this is not a new insight. As discussed earlier in the article, literature in new social movements has done a remarkable job of excavating the pitfalls of collective identity. Where this article departs from existing scholarship is by turning this lens on questions of masculinity.

Collective identities have been problematized in a range of arenas. Intersectional critiques have brought these insights to the study of gender, revealing the unexamined raced and classed bases of second wave feminism's notions of "sisterhood" (hooks 2000; Lorde 2007). This work reveals the tenuous nature of identity construction, and shows how identities are open to contestation and challenge. Surprisingly, there has been comparatively little empirical attention to how these processes pertain to masculinity. Masculinity, especially hegemonic masculinity, continues to be associated with authority, efficacy, and stability. The case of VFJ suggests, however, that gender scholars need to develop more robust understandings of the vulnerabilities and frailties of masculine constructions.

Existing literature also illustrates that collective identity poses risks across a range of settings. The process may, however, be especially hazardous within the kind of organizational context described in this article. Resource poor, voluntary organizations that preside over a diverse and internally differentiated membership base may find themselves hard pressed to motivate members around a common discourse. In the case of VFJ, ethnic and occupational cleavages among vendors shaped interpretive disagreements over masculinity. While Egyptian and American vendors espoused militancy and individuality, the relatively poorer Bangladeshi and West African vendors emphasized kinship and financial interdependence. When the Egyptians and Americans attempted to steer brotherhood around their notions of masculinity, the Bangladeshis and West Africans simply withdrew. They withdrew because they could, and because the costs of participating quickly outpaced the benefits of being a VFJ member. Ironically, organizations like VFJ may be more likely to turn to collective identity as an organizational strategy in the first place. Staff members at VFJ thought that brotherhood would help them steer around resource constraints. Instead, resource constraints created discord between brothers and limited brotherhood's appeals.

VFJ leaders' failure to recruit members into the folds of brotherhood illustrates how gender is constructed from the bottom up as well as the top down. Organizations face limits in their abilities to manipulate gender for institutional purposes. This case does, of course, leave open the possibility that organizations may be able to "do gender" with greater success if they are more inclusive.

VFJ's insistence on a collective identity based on overly rigid notions of masculine equality and militancy could have made the project of gender construction an unduly uphill battle.

Comparative analysis of collective action reveals how movements need to adopt "multi-identity politics" that address multiple social injustices. Instead of silencing internal differences, multi-identity politics recognize all members' issues (Kurtz 2002). Similarly, theoretical and empirical explorations of gender construction show how internal diversity and hybridity are actually essential to the viability and flexibility of "hegemonic masculinity" (Demetriou 2001). Adaptability and flexibility, rather than exclusion, may be keys to successful gender construction in a rapidly changing world (Meuser 2003; Sherman 2009; Taga 2003). Men who adopt more inclusive masculinities may be more likely to form strong emotional bonds with other men (Anderson 2009).

Expanding on this emergent literature, this article has worked through a negative case, analyzing what happens to organizations when notions of masculinity remain relatively rigid and exclusionary. Things may have turned out differently at VFJ if its leaders had incorporated notions of masculine responsibility and care into the rhetoric of brotherhood. An expansive discursive strategy may have helped the organization forge alternative protest strategies and stemmed the rounds of recriminations aimed at members who failed to live up to brotherhood's masculine ideals. This revamped form of brotherhood may have continued to exclude the minority group of women within the organization, but could have proven to be more hegemonic among men, partially living up to the collective potentials for which it was envisioned. To achieve this alternative, VFJ would have had to restructure itself: creating greater opportunities for less privileged vendors to rise the ranks to leadership positions, and institutionalizing new forms of decision making where members had greater voice in movement strategies.

VFJ members faced numerous obstacles to collective action. They were impoverished, over-regulated, and ethnically and occupationally segregated. The promise of a collective identity lay in creating some semblance of unity in the face of all these challenges. Unfortunately, VFJ's discursive choices further aggravated divisions within its membership base, pushing women away and denigrating the concerns and travails of less privileged men. Counter to existing thought on manhood and masculinity, VFJ's story provides a possible explanation for some of the internal dynamics that render hegemonic masculinity a frail and unstable achievement.

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